I Can't Stop Feeling (i want her love)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28826694.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Minor appearances from other characters idk, Pining, true pining I don't think I've ever written that, emotional companionship, slowish burn, As slow as I'm capable of writing, Fluff, Romance, tiny bit of hurt/comfort and angst, this is for all intents and purposes a non-sexual sugar daddy au, I don't either, Modern AU

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by catrasredemption (dimensionhoppingrose)

Summary

"Mmhm." She was suspicious, which was fair , Adora thought. It probably all seemed sketchy. "And what would *you* get out of this?"

"Your company." Catra raised an eyebrow . "I'm serious. I live a very isolated life. It's hard to make friends when you're running one of the biggest companies in the country."

Catra opened and closed her mouth a few times, clearly stunned. Adora had to smirk a little, proud of herself for that reaction. "Here." She pulled out her wallet, counting out a few hundred dollar bills. "Three went on the table for the meal, and for the waitress, and two went to Catra, along with a business card. "Think about it. Call me if you're interested."

"And if I'm not?"

Adora shrugged, standing. "Then you just got a free meal to listen to me talk. Not a bad trade off, right?"

She didn't want to be too smug, but she was pretty sure she had Catra's attention as she walked away.

Notes

So I know this is probably kind of weird. I just really like exploring emotions in situations that would generally be considered sexual? Like just paying for emotional companionship. It was probably a better idea in my head than it is on metaphorical paper.

See the end of the work for more notes

Glimmer

[illegible]

[illegible]

Adora

[illegible]

Bow

[illegible]

Glimmer

[illegible]

Adora

[illegible]

Adora sighed inwardly, turning her phone off and tucking it away. If asked, she'd admit she didn't even remember what this dinner meeting was for, or why she was spending the night with four colleagues she would classify at best as "people I know." But a good meal on the company's dime never hurt.

Her colleagues arrived, settling in, and within moments they were greeted by the waitress Adora had been watching run around for ten minutes. Her wild hair was pulled back in a ponytail that somehow managed to be chaotic and tame at the same time, tan skin standing out in stark contrast to the white of the uniform shirt all the staff members wore. "Welcome to Half Moon." Her tone was even, almost neutral, as she handed out the menus, just a bit on the right side of

cheery. She was clearly practiced in this. "My name's Catra, I'll be your server this evening. Can I start you off with some drinks?"

And the meal began. They put in their drink orders, then promptly forgot about the waitress as the talking started. Quarterly earnings and stocks and projects and all the business chatter that Adora understood and found dead boring. She couldn't remember the last time she'd had a conversation that hadn't started with, "*Are you seeing someone...*"

The waitress was nearly perfect the entire night. Their drinks and food came in a timely fashion, always with a smile, she checked in just the right amount, topping off drinks whenever she saw they were running low. But Adora knew the people who worked for her – knew the people her father had surrounded himself with before his health began to decline and he'd been forced to hand the company over to his daughter. None of them were going to tip the girl. They didn't believe in handouts.

Adora had a feeling the waitress was aware of this as well. It never showed when she was at the table, but she definitely caught her casting a resentful look at their table once or twice. She wondered how many times the girl had served parties like this only to be stiffed by people who believed "hard work" was the only way to earn money.

"Can I get anything else for you?" she asked politely when it was clear the meal was wrapping up, almost two hours later.

"Just the check," one of the men said without looking at her.

"Of course. Is that all on one bill?"

"Yes, please," Adora said, giving the girl a real smile. She probably didn't notice. Bow had worked a job like this through college, and admitted that he stopped paying attention to customers after awhile; he just listened for keywords so he knew what to say or do.

The conversations began to wrap up, her colleagues standing to leave as Catra returned with the check. Adora signed the slip quickly and handed it back. The waitress tried her damndest not to let any of them see the cloud that momentarily marred her expression when she noticed there was no tip.

Another thing Bow had told her – tips on cards took forever to go through, and the whole tip rarely made it to the server. She quickly went through her purse, finding a couple hundred dollar bills and tucking them under the plate before she left.

She ended up back at Half Moon about a week later for lunch with a "friend" – someone she knew through work and kept a relationship with out of pure politeness. Again, they were seated in Catra's area. The waitress looked surprised to see Adora again, which in turn surprised Adora. Did she remember her?

"Welcome to Half Moon. I'm Catra, and I'll be your server today. Can I start you off with some drinks?"

Adora made a habit of going to Half Moon more often, mostly for business dinners, but also on her own a couple of times. Somehow, she always managed to end up in the area Catra was working in. Maybe it was luck, or maybe she just had the highest turnover and the most empty seats.

She made sure to leave a good tip every time.

"Okay, what gives?"

Adora looked up from her menu, surprised. It had been a month since her first dinner here, and this was the first time the waitress dropped any pretenses and looked at Adora with open suspicion.

"What?"

"You have way too much money to blow if you can afford to come here ten times in one month and leave hundreds of dollars in tips." Catra put her hands on her hips, raising an eyebrow. Adora raised one right back.

"I'm surprised you remember a face that well."

"It's hard to forget someone who tips more than she pays for a meal," the waitress replied dryly. "Seriously, what's your deal?"

"Nothing." Adora noted the defensive tone in her voice. "I just like the food. It's not like I ask to be put in your section."

Catra hums, taking out her notepad. "Sure. Do you want a drink?"

Adora enjoyed her meal as she watched Catra work. It was Sunday, and the restaurant was mostly empty. "You work a lot," she said after a moment, for lack of anything else to say.

"Yeah, grad school doesn't pay for itself."

"What're you studying?"

"Cognitive and behavioral neurosciences with a focus on the history of serial killers."

Adora blinked a few times, mouth hanging open. "I can't tell if you're joking or not."

Catra smirked. "Maybe if you come around more you'll find out. Or you can cut out the middle man and just pay me directly for my time."

She walked away, completely unaware of the idea she had sparked in Adora's brain.

Glimmer

I saw the Blood Moon

Bow

R r soon

Adora

yst ' s b

"You know having a f t e customer in this kind of industry is hard," Catra said as she waited for Adora to finish her text. "But you might have done the impossible."

Adora looked up from a phone, giving the waitress a dazzling smile. "When're you off work?"

The question caught Catra off guard. "Um...in an hour."

"Great. Want to join me for a meal?"

Catra scoffed. "You think I get paid enough to eat here?"

"On me."

Now she looked intrigued. "Sure," she said finally. "Want a drink while you wait?"

The hour passed quickly, with Adora spending most of it on her phone. She finished her drink right as Catra slid uncertainly into the seat across from her, hair still up, a large, flannel hoodie dwarfing her lithe form.

"Like I said, meal's on me. Order whatever you want."

Catra frowned, but perused the menu. The baffled coworker who took over the section came to take their drink orders, raising an eyebrow at Catra. She shrugged in return.

"Are you trying to bribe me into telling you if I was serious about the serial killer thing?"

Adora smiled, resting her chin on her hand. "Partially , yes," she said honestly. "You gave me an idea last time we talked."

"You're not going to become a serial killer , are you? I mean, I can totally tell you the best ways to hide a body, but"—

"Paying you for your time." Catra stopped mid-sentence, mouth hanging open. "You've been working every single time I've been here."

"Um. Yeah. Gotta pay tuition somehow."

"What are you studying? Really?"

They paused as the waitress brought them their meals. Catra gave her a small smile before refocusing on Adora. "My thesis is about the history of serial killers and analysis of their mental states. More broadly, I'm studying cognitive neurosciences and Criminology ."

"That' s specific."

Catra shrugged, taking a bite of the fish she had ordered. "The system is fucked, and the best way to change it is to get inside and figure out what's wrong. And the best way to do *that* is to be in a position of observation so you can find the problems."

"So you want to change the entire law system," Adora summarized. "*That'* *s* ambitious."

"I have big dreams."

"Dreams that are hard to accomplish when you're stuck serving tables." Another shrug. "What if I could make it easier?"

"Look, I'm" Catra hesitated, looking around. "I don't judge, but if this is some sex thing"—

"It' s not," Adora said quickly , but smoothly. "I just know a good investment when I see one."

"Mmhm." She was suspicious, which was fair, Adora thought. It probably all seemed sketchy. "And what would *you* get out of this?"

"Your company." Catra raised an eyebrow. "I'm serious. I live a very isolated life. It's hard to make friends when you're running one of the biggest companies in the country."

Catra opened and closed her mouth a few times, clearly stunned. Adora had to smirk a little, proud of herself for that reaction. "Here." She pulled out her wallet, counting out a few hundred dollar bills. "Three went on the table for the meal, and for the waitress, and two went to Catra, along with a business card. "Think about it. Call me if you're interested."

"And if I'm not?"

Adora shrugged, standing. "Then you just got a free meal to listen to me talk. Not a bad trade off, right?"

She didn't want to be too smug, but she was pretty sure she had Catra's attention as she walked away.

Catra did, in fact, call.

Adora invited her over for that Saturday, and there was some debate about how Catra was going to get there. She finally chose the bus over a car from Adora's service, not wanting to make her roommates suspicious. She sounded awfully regretful when she turned down the car, though. Maybe she could be convinced to take one home.

"Make yourself at home," Adora said as she let Catra into her apartment. Catra looked around, mouth hanging open.

"*Every* of my apartment could fit in here."

"It's a bit much," Adora admitted. "The penthouse was an open floor plan, with entire wall of windows overlooking the city. The kitchen

was tucked into a corner, with a clean and clearly unused dining table in the dining area. A large TV adorned one wall;there was a large, overstuffed grey couch in front of it, matching armchairs angled on either side, and a coffee table in front of it. A spiral staircase led up to the master bedroom, and the guest room across the hall from it. "I like the building and the area, though."

Catra just continued to stare, clearly at a loss for words. "All right, hold up," she finally said, turning to Adora in the eye. "You said this wasn't a sex thing."

"It's not," Adora said, tilting her head.

"And you really expect me to believe that you're going to dish out enough money for me to survive without a job just to, what? *Talk* to you? Keep you company?" Catra waved a hand around the apartment. "You could probably make an actual friend out of anyone in this city. Hell, this country. So why're you so eager to pay a poor grad student? And *how* are you smiling about?"

"That," Adora said, unable to keep the slightly gleeful note out of her voice. "You're right, I have people knocking down my door trying to play nice and make *friends* with me. I'm sure you can imagine the kind of people trying to get into my social circle. It's been years since anyone talked to me *for fun*, besides two friends who moved to another city for their own jobs, and I don't get many chances to see them. And if I'm going to pay someone for company, than the money might as well go to something good. Your dreams seem like a good investment."

Catra eyed her uncertainly, and Adora started to feel awkward. This must have seemed so pathetic – she was basically paying someone to pretend to be her friend. What kind of person did *that*? Maybe it would've been better if it *did* involve sex…

"And you'll seriously pay me enough to cover tuition and rent and everything else?"

"Of course." Adora nodded vigorously. "Really, just name your price."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "You realize you're opening yourself for letting a total stranger manipulate you for whatever they want, right?"

"Yeah," Adora admitted.

"And you're okay with that?"

"Maybe I'm really interested in learning about serial killers."

Catra snorted, laughing. Adora grinned despite herself. "Okay." She looked around the room. "Are there rules, or?..."

"I'd prefer if you kept it quiet. But otherwise no. You'll have access to anything and everything you need, mostly no questions. I'm not helping with murder"—

"Damn, that was the first thing I was going to ask about," Catra said, crossing her arms and feigning disappointment. "I guess I'll have to settle for having literally anything else I could ask for."

Catra couldn't believe it.

She was in the world's fanciest car with the softest leather seats, being driven across the city back to her decidedly less impressive apartment in a far poorer neighborhood, with a credit card and a new phone stowed away in her bag—for privacy's sake, Adora had insisted.

And a .

The whole thing made Catra's head spin. This woman couldn't be for real, right? Paying her for...what, company? That was it? Just a warm body to sit and talk with? That was insane. Who did that?

Probably someone desperate enough to pay for it.

She had done her research on Adora Gray, of course. Made CEO of her family's company at twenty-three, after her father had a heart attack and couldn't work anymore. Barely out of college, and she was one of the most influential women in the world overnight.

She seemed genuine, though. The company had done a lot of good work under her management. She was certainly generous with tips—Catra had collected nearly a thousand from her, in cash, in two weeks. Cash tips were rare. Large cash tips were insane. The money had gone toward buying Entrapta the computer she wanted for her birthday;she and Scorpia had scraped their meager earnings together and saved for two months to get it for her. It had been worth it when Entrapta had shrieked and thrown herself at them for a rare hug.

The car pulled up in front of Catra's building. She looked at the driver, who hadn't said a word the entire way, and gave an awkward, "Thanks," along with a wave, before climbing out and making her way to the stairs. It didn't *have* to be a six-floor walk-up if the building management would just get the damn elevator fixed. But they had moved in a year ago, and the elevator had never worked. The walk was a good workout, at least.

"Hey Wildcat!" Scorpia called from the kitchen as Catra let herself in. Their apartment was a wreck compared to Adora's almost *shared* penthouse. The furniture was a bunch of mix and match secondhand stuff bought from goodwill stores or found on the curb waiting for trash day. Every surface was cluttered with bits and pieces of electronics, mail, keys, and grocery bags on their too small kitchen table. Entrapta's bedroom door was closed, by request, because the sight of it made Catra's head hurt. Entrapta swore it all made sense to her. The room Catra shared with Scorpia was in its own state, with clothes thrown everywhere and books abandoned on the floor. But at least Catra was confident she could walk in there without stepping on something sharp. Mostly.

"How was the job interview?"

Right. She'd told Scorpia she was going for a job interview she'd found online—some business person with too much money looking for a personal assistant. And it kind of was that, right? In its own way.

"Uh, pretty good. They offered me the job."

Scorpia lit up, abandoning the pot on the stove to scoop Catra into a tight hug. "That's great! No more restaurant, right?"

"Yeah. No more restaurant." She hadn't put in any notice. She was worried. This was almost too good to be true.

She decided to take the new credit card for a spin the next day. She fully expected the card to be declined, a dead-eyed cashier informing her it had been canceled, or politely asking her to "wait just a minute" while they called the cops to report that a stolen credit card had been brought into their store.

The first stop was a nearby bakery for a muffin. She could cough up a couple bucks if the card was declined, no big deal.

It went through.

Catra stared in shock as the card was handed back to her, along with a muffin. She wandered out of the store in a daze, looking around. Maybe she needed to try something bigger than a two-dollar muffin. Something over twenty dollars. A phone case, she decided. Scorpia needed a new one before she busted her phone screen (again). And she wanted to get one for the Adoraphone. It was the newest release from what the fuck ever, and Catra was surprised it had survived in her bag this far.

She hopped on the bus and headed for Target.

It took a bit of browsing to find suitable phone cases—a heavy duty, light purple one for Scorpia's phone, and a wallet case for Catra's, so she could keep the card and phone together in one place. She went to check out, waiting anxiously while the cashier ran the card. Again,

it went through. Catra tried not to gape as she took the offered bag and hurried out of the store, collapsing on a bench outside.

t or k . She fumbled to get her new phone case out, tucking the phone in and putting the card in one of the empty slots. It fucking worked. She looked at the phone, nervously unlocking it. There were only two numbers – Adora' s and the car service. She hesitated before pulling up a new text thread with Adora and typing.

St acted or k .

An answer came back fairly quickly .

Adora

t happened? Bet er or k

Catra

Yo ur door at eight o'clock st r ng?

Adora

OMG Yo u H?

Catra felt a bit light-headed. An upper limit of twenty-five thousand dollars. She knew in the grand scheme of things, it wasnt a lot. But it was a lot when *she* didnt have to pay one dime of it.

The phone buzzed again. Catra looked down at the text.

Adora

I'm so sorry about this. Please don't hate me.

Catra

Ya ur ht dgt h g

She looked back at the store, then sent another text.

Catra

Ba ur .

Adora was maybe a little *t oo* excited when Catra knocked on her door. She hurriedly went to open it, unable to keep an amused smile off her face when she saw the Target bag in Catra's hand.

"Having fun?"

"I was just testing it," Catra mumbled, ducking her head and stepping into the apartment. Adora didn't blame her for being a little incredulous – it was all a little strange. Besides, you have nothing here for entertainment. What do you even do for fun?"

Adora wilted slightly, closing the door and leading Catra to the couch. "I read. Exercise. This complex has a great gym."

"Ever played a video game?"

The blank look on Adora's face must have answered the question; Catra laughed. "I'm about to change your entire world."

The Target bag had a brand new Switch in it, and several video games and extra controllers. "So that's really all you do?" Catra asked as she started setting up the Switch. "Read and exercise?"

"I sleep."

"That's not a hobby, that's a basic necessity." Catra shook her head. "You don't listen to music or podcasts or anything?"

It was amazing how they could be so close in age – Adora was only a year older than Catra – and yet live in completely different worlds.

"Some music. No podcasts."

"I'd recommend some, but the ones I like are all about true crimes and murder and horror."

"True crime seems to be a thing with you," Adora pointed out. Catra smiled crookedly.

"What can I say? I'm an armchair detective in my free time."

"What's that?"

"Ever heard of Reddit? Wait, you know what the internet is, right?"

"Yes I know what the internet is," Adora says with a scoff.

"Just making sure. Reddit?"

"Vaguely familiar with it."

"So there's this subreddit dedicated to solving cold cases and crimes the police don't have any leads on. It's called being an armchair detective."

"Have you actually solved mysteries?"

"I haven't personally, but the subreddit has actually led to a lot of cases being resolved. It's really cool." There was a certain shine in Catra's split-colored eyes as she spoke. It was cute. "What's your wifi password?"

Adora blushed, looking at the ceiling. "*bowtothehorde*. Lowercase. One word." She could feel the look Catra was giving her. "My friend set it up for me, and I don't know how to change it."

"Oooooooookay. So I'm guessing your wifi is GlimmerAndBow with a bunch of hearts?"

"I don't know how to change that either."

I can probably help you out with that if you want.” She tapped the password into the Switch, letting it get set up online. “So did you just fall into the family business or was this something you actually wanted to do?”

Adora wasn't really sure how to answer that. In truth, it was basically what she had been raised for. Her parents had been telling her for as long as she could remember that this was what she *had* to do with her life, and part of her believed it. The rest of her just accepted the reality for what it was.

“A bit of both, I guess. The perks don't hurt.” She gestured around her apartment. “I have access to the company's private plane as well.”

“You ever take it anywhere fun, or is it all business?”

Adora coughed, rubbing the back of her neck. “I uh... borrowed it for a vacation last year to celebrate Glimmer getting a new job. It was just us and Bow, and just for a couple of days.”

The Switch dinged, and Catra went to plug in the docking station, then carefully probed the TV to hook it up. “What a rebel,” she said teasingly as she joined Adora on the couch again, handing her a controller.

“I just told you I have no idea how to play anything.”

“The only way to learn is by doing. And Mario Kart is a great place to start, trust me.”

It took four races to figure out that Catra was absolutely messing with her. Not that the game was *hard*. Adora just wasn't good, and Catra was.

“Are you enjoying humiliating me?” she asked with a pout as Catra crossed the finish line in first ~~a~~gain.

"Sort of. But hey , you came in sixth this time. You're getting better."

The smile Catra gives Adora made her feel warm. This had been the best afternoon she'd had in a long time.

Catra's phone went off, distracting her. She dug it out of her bag, accepting the call. "Hey , Scorpia —yeah, no, I just got distracted — hey, remember that conversation we had about trying to Mom me?" She paused for a moment, taking a deep breath. "It's fine, just...cool it, please? I'll be home soon."

Adora raised an eyebrow as Catra ended the call, sighing. "Friend?"

"And roommate. She's great, she really is, but she..." Catra rubbed her temples and shook her head. "Never mind, doesn't matter . I should get going."

"Right, it's late, huh?" Adora hadn't realized what time it was. Talking and video games took up a *lot* of time.

"Good thing I've got a private car service at my beck and call," Catra said with a wry smile. Adora beamed.

"I'm glad you're using it." Especially this late. The bus didn't seem safe. Not that she doubted Catra's ability to take care of herself.

"Who am I to argue with a free ride?"

Catra groaned, resting her head on her laptop. "Entrapta, turn down the music!" she yelled for at least the fifth time in the last three hours. "I can't focus!"

"It *is* down!" Entrapta yelled back. Catra closed her eyes and counted to ten. Scorpia was out with her girlfriend, of course, not there to remind Entrapta that Catra's hearing was sensitive —and that Entrapta's own hearing was slightly damaged from the Incident several years earlier.

She needed a break anyway, she decided, rolling over to grab her Switch off the charger. She had originally left it for Adora, feeling weird about just taking it, but Adora had promptly bought her own after discovering Animal Crossing and Pokemon. And, as she had pointed out, she didn't need two, so Catra ended up bringing the original one home, along with the games she'd bought. Scorpia had been dubious about the spending spree. Entrapta had been excited about having someone else to play with.

Adora was online, of course, playing Animal Crossing. Catra smiled, getting out the Adoraphone to text her.

Catra

How's your island?

Adora

It's great! But there's room for one more if you're bored

Or couple

Do you want to visit?

Catra

Sure, Adora

She started up the game and went straight to the airport. Adora had been out of town for the last week on business, and Catra was surprised to find that she missed her.

It had been a month since the start of their arrangement, and it was turning out to be a lot less awkward than Catra had originally expected. Adora was easy to talk to, and loved to ask endless questions about Catra and her interests and she didn't judge.

Catra

W

Adora

H

Catra

D

Adora

O

H

She was such a nerd, Catra thought fondly as she started exploring. The island looked *only* different from the last time Catra had been here. Adora rearranged things every couple days. She was apparently really good at playing the turnip market, if she could afford to move buildings at her whim.

Catra

I

Adora

I

Catra

I

Adora

Y

Catra rolled her eyes. She smiled when she saw one of her stone patterns dotting the ground. Adora couldn't draw for shit, but she loved everything Catra had customized for her island and liked her to share them.

Adora

t r ydaeDhaDW Eofg?

Catra

Yes, I'm sure that's not what you're

Adora

But I'm sure Just as sweet as you

Catra

Well you're not wrong But so is

Half a world away, tucked into her hotel room after a long day of meetings she had already forgotten about, Adora sat on her bed and grinned at her phone screen. Smash Brothers was a lot easier than Mario Kart;Adora had used it for some well-deserved revenge.

Adora

But I'm OK

I'm not sure

Catra

I'm sure you're not

Adora

Am I interrupting?

Catra

Get your pets!

Adora

Open, first legs!

Catra

Hold

Adora

What, her legs

Catra

Good

Sometimes Catra forgot she was being paid.

Not that she wasn't highly aware of the credit card always burning a hole in her pocket, or the fact that that she no longer received bills for her student loans. But she enjoyed spending time with Adora. They usually spent the entire weekend together, and talked a lot during the week. Catra had almost spent the night a couple times, but that was a line she didn't want to cross. And Scorpia was already suspicious enough about her new "job"—and the long hours she seemed to work on weekends only.

She had introduced Adora to one of her favorite true-crime podcasts, and Adora had gone down the rabbit hole, finding all kinds of new things to listen to. It was fun to listen to her talk about the new stuff she had found.

The true crowning moment was the first time Adora hit Catra with a blue shell and took first place at the last second. Catra stared at the

screen, gaping, before looking at Adora.

"I hate you, and I'm so proud of you."

Adora giggled, throwing herself at Catra and hugging her tight. She was so warm, her grip all encompassing. Catra leaned into it without thinking. Then they realized the position they were in. Adora hurriedly pulled away, blushing slightly.

"S-Sorry , that was"…

"It' s okay," Catra said quickly . "Scorpia hugs me all the time. It' s fine."

She still left a little earlier that night. Thankfully , it was Sunday, so she five days to shake off whatever *that* had been.

Adora was staring at her phone.

She and Catra usually texted over the week ~~it~~ was part of their arrangement. That was what she told herself when they first started, at least. But it was getting harder and harder to deny one simple fact.

She had *fallen* for Catra.

And hell if that wasn't pathetic. She had a crush on the woman she was paying to be her friend. Not that Catra took nearly as much advantage of it as Adora thought she would. She mostly used the credit card to pay for necessities, only making rare extravagant purchases, like the Switch, and a new laptop, and a couple gifts for her roommates. But the point stood. Catra was just doing a job. A job she was *good* at, admittedly, but a job nonetheless. This wasn't anything else to her. She would certainly call it off if she thought Adora was getting too invested. She had promised no sex, and she didn't want sex. But would Catra believe that?

Adora set her phone aside, burying her face in her hands and sighing. This was *dumb* . She couldn't ruin this perfectly good

arrangement with fg . She truly enjoyed Catra' s company. And if she tried hard enough, she could forget that it was all paid.

Catra arrived Friday night, as usual, with determination and a goal in mind. "So this is rhg just about friendship?"

The question surprised Adora. Yeah, the hug had been a bit much, but was she really jumping to conclusions so fast? "Yeah."

"Dtg sexual?"

"Dl, I." Adora hunched up slightly, gesturing for Catra to come inside. Clearly they needed to talk. "I dont.want.sex," she said slowly once they were sitting. "I never have. No one ever believes me. My mom thought something was nog with me and made me go to a doctor." She shrugged uncertainly. "It' s never changed, though."

Catra listened, tilting her head. She didnt look like she was judging Adora, at least. She actually looked a little bit relieved. "Okay. Youre ace. You couldve told me that way sooner."

"i'm.what?"

"Get your laptop."

They spent the night online, Catra teaching Adora about the differences between sexual and romantic attractions. At some point she ended up curled into Adora's side as she scrolled and spoke. It felt so natural to have her there.

Adora tried not to think about it.

Catra growled, clasping her pillow over her head. Then she threw it aside, sitting up.

"That's it!"

Scorpia walked in just in time to see Catra storm into Entrapta's room and yank the cord out of her speakers. "Hey!" Entrapta protested, annoyed. "I was listening to that!"

"You and the rest of the fucking building! Why cant you wear headphones!?"

"They hurt my ears!"

"Heeeeeeeey, okay," Scorpia said quickly, stepping forward. "Let's just calm down a bit"—

"I'm not going to finish my fucking thesis at this rate!"

"I dont see why the noise is so distracting," Entrapta huffed.

"Why dont we wait until youre trying to sleep and Ill show you," Catra snapped back. Scorpia took her arm to gently lead her away, but Catra ripped herself from her friend's grip, storming back to their shared room and shoving things into a bag.

"What are you doing?" Scorpia asked wearily.

"Going."

"Where are you gonna go?"

"Literally anywhere else."

"Wildcat"—

Catra shoved her laptop into her bag, got out the Adoraphone, and threw the bag over her shoulder, storming toward the door and typing.

Catra

You'll be fine.

"Catra, come on, please," Scorpia begged. Catra stopped at the door, taking a deep breath.

"I just need to be somewhere else for the night, Scorpia. I'll come home tomorrow night."

She left. Scorpia didn't stop her. The phone buzzed halfway down the stairs.

Adora

You sound upset.

Catra

Duh.

She was outside calling the car service when Adora answered.

Adora

Come over.

The invitation was exactly what Catra had been hoping for, she realized as she walked to the end of the street and waited. She didn't want to get in the car right in front of her building. Just in case.

Adora answered the door almost as soon as Catra knocked. Adora wouldn't admit she had been watching the street and waiting for Catra. She clearly had her own problems. "You wanna talk about it?" she asked uncertainly, stepping aside to let Catra storm in.

"My roommate just—her music drives me *insane*. She had an accident a few years ago—she's really into robotics, she majored in it, and she was working on something in her dorm room, and it blew up, and it damaged her hearing, and everything is *sobud* with her. And she can't use headphones because they squeeze her head and

hurt, and earbuds dont work well, but I cant *think* when she's playing her music. And she needs music to work, and she works from home so she *always* has it going, and *I* havent been able to work for three days!I cant think, I cant focus. Im never going to get anything done!"

She was pacing frantically as she spoke, bag hanging off her shoulder, eyes wide and slightly wild, and she was definitely yelling. That registered only when she was done, still pacing, flexing her fingers. She stopped to stare at Adora, just short of hyperventilating. Adora was wearing sweatpants and a t-shirt, her hair hanging loose instead of up in the usual ponytail. It was all such a stark contrast to the casual but put together way she usually looked when they were together.

And reality hit her like a truck. She had stormed into the apartment, completely flustered, yelling all her problems like she was talking to a *friend*. Not the person who *paid* her for emotional companionship. At least she hadnt hit anything. But jesus christ, Adora wasnt here to deal with her problems!She paid her , and Catra kept her company. That was it.

"*Fuck*, I..Im sorry ,"she stuttered, hands starting to shake. She couldnt lose this gig. She didnt want to go back to waiting on tables.

She didnt want to lose Adora.

"Im sorry , I shouldnt have come over . I just, I..I have temper issues, Ive been working on it, but..fuck it doesnt matter , Im so sorry, Ill go"—

"No, hey , it's okay,"Adora said quickly , gently grabbing Catra's wrist as she started for the door. "It' s okay. You sound really stressed out. Why dont you sit?"

Catra stared at her, opening and closing her mouth a few times. "I… I shouldnt have come here. This isnt your problem"—

I give you what you need, right?" Adora said. "Right now you need a quiet place to sit down and breathe. So sit down and breathe. Do you like tea? I don't, but Bow swears by it and makes me drink it whenever I'm upset."

Catra smiled weakly. "Scorpia does the same thing."

She sat, trying to calm herself down while Adora made tea. It had been awhile since she'd had an episode like that. Longer since she had lost her temper and walked out like that. She'd mostly calmed down by the time Adora handed her a mug, but her hands were still shaking.

"I'm sorry," she said again, voice cracking. *Fuck*, she was not going to cry after all this.

"You don't have to apologize," Adora assured her. "It's not like I was doing anything."

"This isn't. You shouldn't have to deal with this." Catra waved a hand vaguely. Adora scooted closer, her expression set and serious.

"Catra, look at me." She hesitated before meeting that dull blue gaze. "It's *okay*. I promise. I... I'm glad you felt like you could come here. Just let me know what you need, and I'll do whatever I can to help."

Her voice was so soft, so gentle. Catra's chest felt tight for a moment as tears filled her eyes. "Can... Can I have a hug?" she asked in a small voice. Adora immediately gathered her up, hugging her tight. The knot in her chest loosened; she buried her face in Adora's shoulder, letting out a long breath and clinging to her.

They sat like that for a few minutes, Adora's fingers toying with Catra's hair until she pulled away to look at her. "Why don't you spend the night here? I've got a guest room. And you can stay tomorrow while I'm at work. You'll get plenty of quiet and time to work on your paper."

"Are you sure?" The offer really was appealing. Catra couldn't bring herself to just turn it down.

"Absolutely."

And that was how Catra ended up on the softest bed she'd ever laid on, wearing borrowed sleep clothes and bundled under a comfortable blanket. And it was *quiet*. Blessedly quiet. She fell asleep surprisingly fast.

Something in Adora felt extremely… *full* as she walked into her apartment and saw Catra on the couch, typing away. She looked so *comfortable*. Like she belonged there.

Adora shook the thought off, putting on a smile. "Hey. I've got something for you."

She was a little nervous. It was the first time she'd directly bought something for Catra, and she didn't want to overstep. Last night had gotten a little bit into gray area. She didn't want to ruin anything now.

Catra looked up from her work, blinking in surprise. "You did?"

Adora held up a bag from the electronics store, smiling. "It's nothing much, just… something to help you at home, hopefully."

Catra took the bag, and peaking in to see the box—it was a pair of noise-canceling headphones. The price tag and been badly peeled off, but Catra could guess it was in the triple digits.

"These are." She pulled the box out of the bag, turning it over almost reverently. "*Wow*."

Adora rocked nervously on her heels. "I'm sure you already thought about noise-canceling headphones, I just… wanted to do *something* for you. You were so upset last night, and I—"

"I-It's okay," Catra said quickly, standing up. "You did a lot already. You did...way more than you had to, really. And the headphones are...are great. Thank you."

Adora relaxed slightly, smile back. "Whatever you need, remember?"

Catra nodded slowly, a small smile pulling at her lips. "Yeah."

"This person's voice is so relaxing," Adora said, head falling back to rest on the couch. Catra was lying down with her head on Adora's thigh, letting Adora play with her hair. The lines for physical affection had been slightly blurred since the night Catra had spent here. Something had changed.

"Totally doesn't matter that he's talking about the brutal murder of an entire family, right?" Catra teased. Adora coughed, rubbing the back of her neck.

"I mean, the subject matter is terrible, but"—

Someone knocked on the door.

Adora and Catra exchanged looks, and Catra slowly sat up so they could stare at the door together. "What?..."

"Parents?" Catra suggested, grimacing.

"They live halfway across the world."

Adora stood, going to the door and looking through the peephole. She groaned internally, opening the door.

"Surprise!"

If it had been *not at all*, Adora would've been thrilled to see her best friends standing on her doorstep. But not *now*, not with Catra here. How was she supposed to explain this? *Absolutely*

st at pigeon hospital That didn't sound too pathetic or anything.

"You could at least *pretend* to be happy to see us," Glimmer teased as she and Bow pulled Adora in for a hug. She sighed, wrapping her arms around them.

"You *know* I'm happy to see you, it's just not a great time."

She looked back at Catra, who was staring at them, wide-eyed, probably thinking the same thing Adora was – she did *not* want to have to explain this.

"What do you – oh, who's that?" Bow asked, craning around Adora to get a look at Catra. Adora said the first thing that came to mind.

"My girlfriend."

Why was her first instinct terrible?

Catra, blessedly, was a better actor. She immediately shot up from the couch and made her way over, putting on an easy smile. "Glimmer and Bow, right? Adora talks about you guys all the time. It's great to finally meet you."

"Aaawww, Adora talks about us?" Bow asked, eyes bright. Glimmer looked a little less impressed.

"Funny, she's never said a word about you to us."

"Yeah, that's..." Catra rubbed the back of her head, shifting her weight between her feet. "I wanted to meet you guys in person so you could get to know me without Adora as a barrier."

So good at this. Adora tried to keep her expression neutral, like none of this was news to her. "Well, it's great to meet you!" Bow said enthusiastically, tugging Catra into a hug. She was frozen for a moment, clearly shocked.

"Uh, yeah. You too."

"We brought food," Glimmer said, a little more subdued now, holding up the bags of takeout. "Not sure there's enough for four, though."

"I can go," Catra started to say, but Bow cut her off.

"Nah, we can split some things. Glimmer never finishes all of her food anyway."

And with that, the couple made their way inside, heading for the kitchen. Catra turned to look at Adora as soon as they were out of sight.

"*Glitter*?" she hissed in disbelief.

"It was the first thing I could find!" Adora whispered back, blushing. "I'm sorry. Maybe you could make up an emergency or something?"

"That'll look weird. It's like one of those blind date things where you pretend halfway through the meal to get a call about your dog dying or something." Catra pinched the bridge of her nose, sighing. "Okay, it's cool. It's just dinner."

"You guys coming, or do we have to eat all these nachos ourselves?" Bow called from the kitchen. They exchanged looks and nodded before going to join the couple.

The four settled around the dining table, take out containers open for everyone to share from. It seemed like Bow and Glimmer had gone to several different restaurants – there was Chinese, Mexican, Thai, Italian, and Greek to choose from. Catra took as little as possible from the Chinese food and indulged in a few nachos.

"So," Glimmer said in a tone Catra immediately recognized. "What do you do, Catra?"

"Um..bus tables." It was close enough to the truth. "And go to grad school."

"What're you studying?" Bow , at least, seemed genuinely interested. It made the whole thing feel a little less like an interrogation.

"Cognitive neurosciences and Criminology . I'm mostly working on my thesis now."

"That' s a lot to do when you're working full time."

Catra wondered if Glimmer thought she was subtle. "Yeah, that's why it's taking awhile. I finished all my classes last year, but the paper is a little more complicated."

"How' s teaching going?" Adora asked Bow , trying to put an end to the conversation.

"It' s great! I really thought the private school would be different from public school, and it is, but a lot of it is the same, too. The kids are awesome, of course. They're *really* into robotics, so that's been fun."

"You're into robotics?" Catra jumped on the chance to keep this conversation going. "Do you happen to know anyone named Entrapta?"

Bow immediately lit up. "Yeah! We're on a few of the same forums."

"She' s my roommate."

Bow' s fork clattered against his plate as his mouth fell open. "I'm sorry, what?"

"Is she the one who blew something up in her dorm room?" Adora asked. Catra sighed.

"Yup, that's her."

"So you like… *know* her?"

"We share a living space and I regularly yell at her to turn her music down."

Bow was clearly having a moment. Unfortunately, it left a space open for Glimmer to jump back in. "Where do you live?"

"Across town." Catra gestured vaguely. "Nowhere nearly as nice as this, obviously, but it's a pretty decent apartment for three people."

She grimaced inwardly when she remembered the three might be two soon. Scorpia had been spending a *lot* more time at her girlfriend's apartment lately.

"It must be hard, making rent and all your bills."

"*Hey*," Adora hissed. Catra ignored her.

"No, we're doing pretty good, actually. Scorpia has a steady job and Entrapta has like...three jobs because she can't work one full-time job, and I make good tips."

Glimmer didn't look entirely convinced. There was a tense silence before Bow rescued Catra again; he was looking at the entertainment center, and gasped.

"Adora, did you get a Switch?"

Adora looked back, then at Bow, smiling. "Yeah. Catra's been teaching me about video games. Wanna see my Animal Crossing island after we're done eating?"

"Yes!"

Bow was actually, genuinely nice, and Catra liked him. Glimmer… not so much. She was *fine*, but she certainly wasn't as warm and fuzzy as her husband. And she clearly didn't trust Catra.

Catra wasn't sure why that bothered her so much.

She excused herself to the bathroom after they were done eating, needing a break. Glimmer immediately turned to Adora as they settled on the couch. "Adora—"

"Glimmer, please." Adora cut her off. "I like her."

"I like her too," Bow added as he started up the Switch. "I told you you'd like this stuff if you just tried playing it."

"I'm sure you like her," Glimmer said with a sigh. "And she seems perfectly...nice. But—"

"But no one can care about me without caring about my money." Adora's voice was strangely bitter. That was exactly their arrangement, after all. She had no reason to be upset.

"I didn't say *that*. Just...you have to be careful, you know."

"And I *am* careful."

"She's not asking you to buy her ridiculous things are like, pay her loans or anything?"

"No." Well, she'd already paid the loans. But again, part of the arrangement. "I bought her a new laptop because her old one died, but it was living on borrowed time anyway. She said Entrapta had been keeping it alive. And she didn't ask me to do that."

It was all true enough. Catra *had* bought a new laptop to replace the one she'd been keeping alive for three years beyond its lifetime. Glimmer pursed her lips. "Please, Glimmer? Not everyone wants to use me."

"Give her a chance," Bow said, nudging his wife's shoulder. "She seems nice. And she got Adora to buy something *fun*. You know how hard that is."

Glimmer sighed, giving in. "Okay, okay. I'll try to be nicer."

That lasted until about five minutes into playing Mario Kart. "Did you just hit me with a red shell?" Glimmer demanded, glaring at Catra, who was grinning.

"Sure did. And now I'm taking first. And now I'm winning."

"Rematch," Glimmer demanded. Bow and Adora exchanged looks. This was going to end with Glimmer and Catra being best friends or worst enemies.

Twenty races later, it looked more or less like a friends situation. They were insulting each other, but it was good natured, and Glimmer definitely "accidentally" elbowed Catra a few times. Bow and Adora dropped out after an hour. It was mostly fun to watch the two women play.

Bow leaned over to whisper to Adora. "She seems pretty great."

"Yeah." The gleeful word and the smile that pulled at Adora's lips didn't feel at all forced or pretend. "She is."

Her feelings were rearing their ugly heads again. She grimaced, trying to swallow everything back down and lock it up. Feelings were just going to mess things up. She couldn't do that.

"For what it's worth, I don't think she's trying to use for money."

The words surprised Adora. She blinked at Bow, and he shrugged. "I saw the way she was looking at you while we ate. She's not very subtle."

And just like that, the feelings were roaring back to life. *What the hell?*

"Uh, guys?" Bow said as they finished another race. "It's almost midnight."

"It is?" Catra checked her phone, and groaned when she saw a text from Scorpia asking if she was coming home tonight. "I should get

going”…

“Are you kidding?” Bow asked, stretching. “It’s way too late. Just spend the night. Speaking of”…

Adora rolled her eyes. “Yes, you guys can have the guest room.”

Catra looked uncertainly at Adora. If they took the guest room, there was only really one place *Adora* could sleep.

But Bow was right, it was late. Even with Adora’s car service, she wouldn’t get home until almost one. Adora met Catra’s gaze, and nodded once. It’d be fine.

The bed was big, at least. There’d be plenty of room for both of them. “I’m *so* sorry,” Adora said quietly. “I wasn’t expecting them to just show up, and all of this has been”…

“It’s okay,” Catra said quickly, changing into the clothes Adora had lent her. “Your friends are all right.”

“I’m fond of them.”

They turned off the lights, crawling into bed. There was more than enough space for them to both be comfortable. They were completely separated when they fell asleep.

And completely entangled in each other when they woke up. They had, apparently, drifted to meet in the middle of the bed and curled into each other. Catra was tucked perfectly under Adora’s chin, Adora holding her close.

They stirred around the same time, waking up and realizing their position. Adora stopped breathing, eyes wide. Catra was very quiet, her face hidden in Adora’s chest. They didn’t move until Bow knocked on the door and suggested they go out for breakfast.

Catra was staring at the Adoraphone, a lump in her throat. She'd done a good job, she thought, keeping any errant thoughts away. If she thought Adora was cute – well, it wasn't *wrong*. Objectively, she was attractive. If she enjoyed spending time with Adora regardless of the fact she was getting paid – well, good company was good company.

But there was no denying the way she'd felt when she woke up in Adora's arms. The way it had felt so *right*. So *normal*.

You don't pay someone to cuddle you. You pay someone to get away from you.

Catra rolled over, hiding her face in her pillow. Fucking great. What if she messed this up? Never mind she'd be fully screwed money-wise, she'd lose Adora. And the thought of that was almost unbearable.

Fuck.

"Wildcat?" She looked up to see Scorpia sitting down on her own bed, watching her with concern. "Is...everything okay?"

"Yeah, 'course. Why wouldn't it be?"

"I dunno, you just...you've been acting different lately. Is everything all right at work?"

You don't have to put up with abuse from your boss just because you're scared of losing your job.

"Yeah, Scorpia. Everything's fine. I'm just tired. Too many all nighters trying to finish my thesis."

"You should try to sleep, then. I'll make sure Entrapta keeps the noise down."

"Thanks."

Catra rolled over as Scorpia left the room, turning off the light and closing the door. She set the Adoraphone aside. Maybe it would be

better if they didnt talk every single night this week.

Adora held her phone over her head, staring at it. She wanted to text Catra. To ask her to come over. But it was Wednesday. Catra never came over on weekdays, except for that one Thursday when she'd needed to get away from her roommates. She set her phone aside and rolled over, staring at the TV without really seeing what she was watching.

Was it weird? Paying someone you had feelings for to spend time with you? Adora wasn't trying to take advantage of Catra, but what if she was? What if she'd backed Catra into a corner? She did cover all of Catra's bills and rent. If Catra wanted out of this, she'd have to find another job, and there was absolutely no way she'd find something that paid even half as well as Adora did.

Maybe that was it. That was the mistake. That was what was wrong. She made Catra completely dependent on her without even meaning to.

What would you do?

How could she have been so stupid? So careless? Adora dug the heels of her hands into her eyes, groaning. She had made Catra completely dependent on her, and now she had feelings and was keeping Catra trapped. She had to fix this. She could fix this.

Somehow.

Catra seriously considered asking if they could not meet up that weekend. She needed more time to separate herself from whatever confusing emotions she was feeling toward Adora. But she also really wanted to see Adora despite everything.

At least until Adora opened her door. She looked serious. Too serious. Catra hiked her bag up on her shoulder, trying to smile.

“Hey, Adora.”

The serious expression wavered for a moment. “Hey.” She stepped aside to let Catra in. “I um. I wanna talk to you about something.”

That definitely wasn’t good. “Is everything okay? Did Glimmer poison my food when I wasn’t looking?”

“No.” Adora laughed, then paused. “I don’t think so. No, it’s about this. arrangement.” Catra’s heart jumped to her throat. “I think it might be best if we. stopped. I won’t just leave you hanging! You can keep the card, and I’ll pay you. whatever you think you need to give you time to find a job and have a good savings and everything.”

Catra felt the ground shift slightly beneath her. The money was the last thing on her mind right then. “W-Why?” she asked after a moment. “I thought things were all right?”

“I just. I realized after last weekend that I’ve kind of. cornered you. I don’t want you to be completely dependent on me. That’s not fair to you.”

“I’m fine with it,” Catra said without thinking. She *was* fine with it. If it meant she could spend time with Adora, she was fine with anything.

“Yeah, you are *now*, but what if. what if you want to move out of the city, or start dating someone, or you just want a new job, and you can’t do any of that because I’ve. I’ve done this.” She waved a hand miserably. “And you can’t get out?”

Catra stared at her, mouth hanging open. Then she laughed. It was a small, humorless laugh, and it didn’t last long; she had to close her mouth before she started crying. “You think I want to do *any* of those things?”

Adora blinked, staring at her in surprise. “What?”

"I mean, yeah, once I finish my thesis I'd probably want a job that I actually went to grad school for, but that's so far off. I want to stay in the city. I like the city. It's amazing. And I... I don't want to date anyone else."

Adore. Adora refused to think too much about the implications of that. "I mean, sure, you don't *owe*, but what if—"

"What if I just want to be with you?" Catra cut her off, voice shaking. "Keep the money, the card, your phone, I don't care. All of that stopped mattering... fuck, I don't even know when."

Adora felt like her ears were ringing. Was she really saying...? No, that couldn't be right. Could it? "Do you... mean that?"

Another small laugh. "Yes, dummy." Catra dug through her bag, finding the wallet case and holding it out to Adora. "Take it. I've got… *more* than enough savings from the monthly payments. That's plenty of time for me to find a new job. Hell, I could probably coast for a couple months on what I have now."

It felt completely impossible. The idea that Catra would just want to *be* with her... was this how Catra had felt when Adora had first proposed this arrangement? "You really?..."

Catra stepped forward, pushing the phone into Adora's hand. "I really." A thought seemed to occur to her in that moment; her expression fell. "I-I mean, if *you* want—"

She was cut off by Adora tackling her, pulling her into a tight hug. "I want," she whispered, holding her close. "I really, *really* want."

Catra was frozen for a moment before she pushed herself up on her tiptoes, arms winding around her. "Okay," she whispered into Adora's shoulder.

It was their first date.

Adora hadn't really been forthcoming with the details of *where* they were going, although she promised it wouldn't be anywhere that charged more for a meal than they paid their employees. So Catra did her best to dress accordingly—a dark red dress shirt with black pants, and a nice pair of shoes. There. That probably wasn't too bad.

"So you're going on a date," Scorpia said slowly, watching Catra get ready.

"Yup."

"With the CEO of one of the most powerful companies in the world."

"Yup."

"And how did you meet?"

"Through work."

Technically, it wasn't a total lie. Scorpia pursed her lips. "Okay," she said slowly. "If you're *really* sure about this"—

"Trust me, Scorpia. I am *more* than sure about this."

Her phone buzzed—Adora letting her know she was there. She'd been pretty adamant about wanting to meet Catra at the door, and Catra had been just as adamant that she was *not* going through the torture of meeting her roommates.

"I'll be *fine*," Catra assured Scorpia again. "Don't wait up."

"Have fun." Scorpia was incapable of sounding anything but optimistic, even when she wasn't sure about something.

Adora was practically bouncing in her seat as Catra climbed into the car. "Clothes okay?" she asked uncertainly.

"You look great."

Catra rolled her eyes, smiling. "I *am* for our mysterious date destination, you dork."

"Oh." Adora blushed. "Yeah, they're good."

They spent most of the ride chatting idly. Adora was *half* trying to play Pokemon again despite her reluctance to make them fight. "Why can't there be a game where you just raise them without fighting? I want to run a daycare."

"Maybe the next game will have that option."

"You think they'll make another one?"

Catra sighed. "Oh, Adora. We have *so much* to catch you up on still."

The car pulled to a stop, and Adora smiled mischievously, climbing out. "Maybe this'll be a good place to start."

It was a restaurant/bar combination, with an entire section dedicated to the *really* old arcade games. Adora already had a hefty bag of quarters. Catra looked around in wonder, a smile pulling at her lips.

"Very smooth."

They ate first, then got drinks and went to check out the arcade section. Of course, the first thing they had to play was Mario Kart. It had a seat and steering wheel and pedals, and they both did absolutely terrible.

"That steering wheel is super janky," Catra complained as Adora dragged her to another game. "I want a rematch later."

"Later when you're probably going to be drunk?"

"Exactly. I'll be in the right state of mind to deal with whatever nonsense that was."

The next game was a top down space shooter game. They pressed next to each other at the small machine, rapidly pressing buttons and yelling orders at each other even as they lost spectacularly.

Three hours and several drinks later, they sat down at the Mario Kart machine again. Catra's theory that she would be in the right state of mind did *not* pan out – she spent most of the game trying to get away from the wall.

"Guess that's why you don't drive drunk," Adora said with a giggle.

"Good thing you have a car service."

They stood out on the sidewalk while they waited, the fresh air sobering them up a bit. But they were still leaning on each other. "So do you want to go home, or?..."

"I am *not* climbing six flights of stairs." Catra yawned, resting her head on Adora's shoulder.

"Y'know, I bet I could get the building management to fix that elevator."

Catra laughed. "Using your power for good. I like it."

Adora looked down, meeting Catra's gaze. They both smiled stupidly for a minute. "I *really* like you," Adora said finally.

"That's good, 'cause what I'm about to do would be really awkward if you didn't."

She got up on her tiptoes, and kissed Adora.

It turned out books lied. Kissing Catra wasn't like an explosion, or fireworks, or any grandiose thing. It was comfortable, almost familiar. Like they had been made exactly for this.

"Wow," Adora said when Catra pulled away. She laughed, smacking Adora's arm.

Don't ruin it."

She wouldn't. That was what she promised herself as the car arrived, and she helped Catra in before getting settled as well. Catra leaned against her, head on her shoulder, eyes closed, and Adora promised herself, again and again, that she wouldn't ruin this. She wouldn't get too caught up in her head and worry about her feelings messing everything up. She was going to enjoy this, for however long it lasted.

(Hopefully forever.)

End Notes

Reviews are known to be more nutritious to writers than real food.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!